

The LDF stirs a hornet's nest as it files an affidavit in the Supreme Court seeking entry for women into Lord Ayyappa's abode

Photographs by SHANWAR



the ban is lifted. "Records show the Maharaja of Travancore, accompanied by the Maharani, had visited the temple in the past," says the affidavit. The Government has listed the rituals and customs at the shrine that have been altered in the past years to suit the changing times. Annoying Hindu groups further, it has even suggested that the temple might have been a Buddhist shrine in the past. "The words '*Saranam Ayyappa*' uttered by the pilgrims are synonymous with the Buddhist *Saranatrayam* of *Buddham Saranam, Dharmam Saranam, Sangham Saranam*

COLLISION COURSE



"We will protect all rights under the Constitution. We can't discriminate on the basis of gender."

G. SUDHAKARAN
MINISTER FOR TEMPLE AFFAIRS



"They consult minorities on all issues concerning them. Why don't they do the same with Hindus?"

P.K. KRISHNADAS
STATE BJP PRESIDENT

Gachhami," says the affidavit. Expectedly, the Government's position has been challenged by staunch Hindus. Kandararu Mahadevaru, the head priest at Sabarimala, says no change in the tradition and customs will be allowed. "There are different customs and traditions in different temples. They cannot be altered by the governments of the day," he says. He questions the interference in Hindu traditions and customs by the regime, which, according to him, did not dare to touch those of the Muslims or Christians. The Hindu Aikyavedi has dubbed the Government's move as an

attempt to divide the community. "We are not against change in customs and traditions in accordance with time. However, it is not the government but devotees and religious leaders who should initiate it. The Government should withdraw the affidavit that has been filed without any discussion with devotees or acharyas," says Kummanam Rajasekharan, Aikyavedi general secretary and VIP leader. "Can the Government order that women be allowed in mosques at the time of prayer or dispense with the custom of covering their heads inside mosques or churches?" he asks. BJP has blasted the Government for unilateral attempts to alter Hindu customs. "The Government goes out of its way to discuss issues with minority leaders. Why can't they do the same with Hindu leaders before attempting to change the centuries-old practices?" asks P.K. Krishnadas, state BJP president. Former TDP president and Congress(I) leader K. Raman Nair has also opposed any change in the temple customs.

Hindu leaders say that the traditional ban was not an anti-women measure but a result of the consideration shown towards them. "The ban came about long ago only to spare them from the difficulties they would encounter during the arduous pilgrimage to the hill shrine located in the forests. Today the festival season witnesses crores of pilgrims converging at the temple from all over the country and there could be law and order problems for women as even basic facilities are lacking," says Rajasekharan. "All pilgrims are required to observe a strict penance of 41 days called *vrath*, during which they have to abstain from non-vegetarian food, liquor and sex. Women of menstrual age cannot observe this penance," says C. Vijayakumar of the Ayyappa Sewa Sangham. "It is believed that Lord Ayyappa of Sabarimala is a *brahmachari* god and hence, does not wish to be distracted by the presence of young women. There are hundreds of other temples in the state. The ban is a custom peculiar to this shrine and it should not be altered unilaterally," he says. It seems the Government has bitten off more than it can possibly chew. ■